

Subject: Management

Production of Courseware

 **-Content for Post Graduate Courses**



Paper: 07, Business Communication

Module: 03, Principles of Communication



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Items	Description of Module
Subject Name	Management
Paper Name	Business Communication
Module Title	Principles of Communication
Module Id	Module – 03
Pre- Requisites	Meaning and Types of Communication
Objectives	To understand the Principles of Communication and how application of these principles make the communication more effective.
Keywords	7Cs, 4Ss, effective communication, brevity, consideration.



QUADRANT-I

Module 03: Principles of Communication
1. Learning Outcome
2. Introduction
3. Principles of communication
3.1 Seven Cs
3.2 Four Ss
4. Relevance of different principles
5. Summary

1. Learning Outcome

By the end of this module the students will be able to understand

- The various principles of communication.
- How messages can become more effective.
- Guidelines to be followed while sending a message.

2. Introduction

It seems so simple: say what you mean. But it is not always so simple. Often our intended message gets lost in transmission in spite of our best intentions. Communication is much more than exchanging information. Communication at the work place can be your best friend or your enemy. It's not only how you are sending a message so that it is received and understood by receiver in the same way you intended, it's also how you listen to gain the full meaning of what's being said and also to assure the person that he has been heard and understood. So luckily we can learn how to communicate more effectively and clearly. And for effectiveness of communication there are certain principles of both oral as well as written communication. These principles if used help the communicators to communicate even negative or complex messages without creating conflict or destroying trust.



3. Principles of Communication

For effective message you need to apply certain communication principles. They all tie closely with the basic concepts of the communication process and are important for transmitting effective written and oral communications. Interestingly, seven of them begin with the alphabet C and four with S. They are:

7 Cs- Completeness, Conciseness, Consideration, Concreteness, Clarity, Courtesy and Correctness.

4 Ss- Shortness, Simplicity, Strength and Sincerity.

(Source: Asha Kaul, **Effective Business Communication**, PHI Learning Private Limited, New Delhi)

All these principles are not mutually exclusive in fact they overlap in many of the factors influencing these principles. Now we discuss these principles in detail:

3.1

7 Cs of Effective Communication



3.1.1 Completeness

Completeness means quantum of information needed for making a message complete and business message is "complete" when it has all the necessary information which is required for the receiver of the message to act in a particular way. Considering that receivers differ in their mental filters as they are influenced by their backgrounds, viewpoints, needs, attitudes, status, and emotions, so the message should be complete in itself to minimize the possibility of different understanding of the same message by the different receivers.

Completeness is important for many reasons.

First, if the message is complete then the probability of the desired response of the sender becomes very high without incurring extra cost on additional messages.

Second, complete messages are helpful in developing and maintaining the goodwill of the organization.

Third, since the message is complete and no information is extra or omitted, the chances of legal actions against the organization are minimized.

So the sender should ensure that communication messages which are sent are complete to avoid misunderstanding and delayed action. It is advisable that the message which is transmitted always has a logical conclusion so that the receiver is clear about what has to be done.

The message must be self-sufficient, that is, it must hold well on its own without support from other messages.

Examples:

- i. When factory supervisor gives instructions regarding production of goods to the workers, he must specify the exact size, shape, quality and cost of the product. If there are any underlying assumptions to those instructions then they must also be clearly stated
- ii. While answering a letter, all the questions raised in the letter must be replied.
- iii. An assignment is given to you by your team leader. The assignment is important and its acceptability will be reflected in your appraisal. Unfortunately, may be because of paucity of time, you are not able to put your best effort and present rigorous analysis of the situation. You provide data that lacks analytical thinking and hence based on that report, due to lack of completeness the decision cannot be taken.

Following points should be kept in mind, for completeness of message:

1. Include all the essentials.
2. Answer all questions asked.
3. Give something extra, when desirable.
4. Check for the five W's:
(i) Who (ii) What (iii) Where (iv) When & (v) Why

e.g. To give instructions regarding the delivery of a consignment of readymade garments to the dealer, one should consider 5 Ws to draft the message-

- Who will deliver the consignment?
- What items will form a part of the consignment?
- When the consignment has to be delivered?
- Where the consignment has to be delivered?
- Why it needs to be delivered on time with efficiency?

5. Incomplete messages create confusions in the receivers mind and thus receiving proper feedback becomes impossible.
6. A message to be meaningfully complete must be a value addition to the receiver.

3.1.2 Conciseness

Conciseness means the ability of conveying what you have to say in the minimum possible words with maximum possible meaning conveyed, that is, without sacrificing the other C qualities of the message. Conciseness is desired because a concise message saves time and expense for both sender and receiver. One should be brief and be able to say whatever one has to say. Conciseness preserves the focus of the message by eliminating redundant information. Quantum of information should be just right, neither too much neither too little.

Business communication is founded on the principle of brevity. This principle applies not only to the length but to the contents of the message as well. So while writing messages always write short and meaningful sentences. Try to avoid technical jargons unless the message is being sent to a very specialized group. This principle of communication should be adopted for both internal as well as external communications.

Following points should be kept in mind to draft concise messages:

1. **Brevity and relevance:** The quantum of information should be provided on the basis of needs and expectations of the receiver.
2. **Avoid jargons:** Jargons refer to words that are subject specific. Avoid jargons as they confuse rather than increase understanding.
3. **Use audience relevant words:** Words that are simple and relevant to the context should be used so that receiver can understand them and relate to them.
4. **Avoid unnecessary repetition:** Repetitions of some words, points and examples make audience disinterested in the topic and make them boring and consequently communication stops.
5. **Eliminate wordy expressions:** It means that when the message can be conveyed in lesser words don't burden the message with more words and long sentences.
6. **Include only relevant statements, material:** If unnecessary words are included or irrelevant themes are added in the message the real focus of the message is lost and the receivers end being confused, so the desired behavior will not follow after transmission of the message.

Example:

- i. Wordy message: She was very expressive in absolutely rejecting the newly assigned responsibility.
Concise message: She firmly rejected the new responsibility.
- ii. If you can manage your time well, it can lead to a growth on the job front. Having control over the way you spend your time can help you do a lot of work during the day. The more effectively you manage your time, the higher your career will soar.

All that is being said here is that *time management* skill is important for a successful career.

3.1.3 Consideration

Consideration means that you should prepare every message by keeping recipient in mind and by putting yourself in his or her place. Before drafting the message think about their psychological and circumstantial situations, their limitations, aspirations and likely reactions to the message and accordingly design the message. So under this principle receivers' needs are kept in mind while designing the message. The message could be an office order, a circular, an advertisement, CEO's speech for her employees, a sales letter etc. But care has also to be taken that consideration does not compromise on the interests of the organization

Another aspect of this principle is that one should also adopt one's language and message content so that the rest of the six C's of good business communication are taken care of. So as per the receivers needs the message should be made complete, concise, concrete, clear, courteous, and correct.

Following these specific ways you can indicate you are considerate:

1. Empathize with the receiver:

Use concepts and language with which the receiver can relate. Show respect to the sentiments, ideas, notion, concept and values of the receiver. Try to put yourself in the position of the receiver and answer the following questions: what are your expectations and needs as the receiver? What is your perception about the issue under discussion? What will be your response in the current situation? Has the content of the discussion been intellectually and emotionally satisfying?

Answer of these questions will help in framing a message that shows consideration for the receiver.

2. Bond with the audience:

Focus on 'you' or 'we' instead of 'I'.

Example:

Head of the Sales team instead of saying –

“ In the last quarter my team has performed very well but in coming months you all have to generate even higher targets so you have to get ready.

He should say-

“ In the last quarter all of us as a team have performed very well but in coming months we have to generate even higher targets so all of us should get ready”

Message drafted with a 'we' approach will be received well and result in positive response.

3. Be receiver friendly:

Message should be designed keeping the receiver's perspective in mind. While communicating with the receiver, discourteous words or tone should not be used, both in written as well oral communication, unless the situation especially demands like in case of reprimand.

Example:

A customer approaches the sales outlet complaining about the damaged micro wave oven which does not work properly, wanting it's replacement.

The salesperson says-

“The oven has very complicated system and requires careful handling. You must not have read the owner's manual and understood how to operate the oven.”

Here we can see that even if the intension is not such, this message is humiliating for the customer which might result in loss of good will or legal action on the part of customer against the shop or the brand.

The sales person should have said instead-

“We will show it to our engineer and review for any fault and get it repaired. If nothing wrong is found then our customer care associate will revise with you the operational details of the oven for it’s smooth functioning.”

This message will increase the goodwill of the company.

4. **Be honest and ethical:**

Message should indicate honesty in character and integrity in approach. All the details should be collected and presented in a manner that presents a true picture to the receiver.

Example:

Imagine a pharmaceuticals company which has come out with a new medicine which contains a component that might cause reaction in asthmatic patients. If the company wishes to be recognized as an honest and ethical company, it is important to mention possible allergic reactions on the packing to avoid unanticipated illness.

3.1.4 Concreteness

Communicating with concreteness means being specific, definite and vivid rather than vague and general regarding the issue under discussion.

Ask yourself a few questions:

- Is the message to the point?
- Have you been specific in presentation of issues?
- What is the goal, the objective of your communication?

Clarity of purpose enhances correctness and specificity. Abstractions or abstract statements can cloud the mind of the sender. The facts and figures presented should be specific.

Example:

- i. “I expect the order to reach me at the earliest”,

The above statement is not a concrete statement as the word ‘earliest’ is vague. Different people may have different understanding of what ‘earliest’ means.

The sender should say-

“I expect the order to be delivered to me on the 21st of November.

- ii. Abstract Words: The student received a high grade in the test.
Concrete Words: Neha received an ‘A’ in the Business Statistics exam.

3.1.5 Clarity

Clarity means designing and getting your message across in such a manner that the receiver understands your message as you intended him to understand. So for receiver to understand the message clearly the sender must design the message keeping in mind the background and understanding level of the receiver.

In communication, a string of words by themselves does not convey meaning. To communicate effectively, a mix of clear concepts and intentions is required. Clarity is required much more in written communication than in oral. Because in case of complexity sender is himself present to explain the issues. But in written communication there is little scope for you to simplify message that lacks clarity.

Example:

For common understanding instead of writing that ‘the website is now fully operational with the e-commerce functionality setup’, one should write ‘the company has launched its website’.

Here are some specific tips to help make your messages clear:

1. Use easily understandable language as per the ability of the receivers of the message.
2. Finish one theme before starting with another in a write up or conversation.
4. Include examples, illustrations, and other visual aids, when desirable.

3.1.6 Courtesy

Communication is an activity of mutual give and take of ideas and information. And in business communication, almost everything starts with and ends in courtesy. If you want the receiver to be polite and to listen, you must be willing to extend the same courtesy to the receiver. Courteous messages help to strengthen present employee as well as business relations, as well as make new relations.

Examples:

- i. While it is easy to say “Shut the door” as it use few words and less energy , the impact of “Can you please shut the door?” is much greater.
- ii. A young executive sending a document to his superior may end the mail with the sentence,

“Please feel free to revert to me in case of any problems or queries.”

The tone in the letter is discourteous and patronizing and not suitable to be used with a superior. Instead he should write,

“Please inform if any clarification is required or any modification is needed to be done.”

- iii. Ashima: “You can never do things right. Try working on this project. If you are lucky you may not have to redo it.”
Better way of stating the above will be-

Ashima: “This is an interesting project. Do you think you can complete it? Last time there were some problems with the project but we can try again and I am sure you would be able to do wonders”.

These above two statements of Ashima convey totally different impressions. On the one side first statement is more accusative, while second one is more tactful and appreciative of efforts put in by the receiver.

To be courteous, communicators should follow these suggestions:

1. Be sincerely tactful, thoughtful, and appreciative: This approach will help you in establishing better relationships with the receiver. By handling situation tactfully you can make strong relationships and make the communication more meaningful.
2. Be respectful: If you want respect from the receiver, you as a sender must take the first step and should show respect to the receiver's ideas and communication.
3. Use the right tone: Your tone of message can vary with the type of relation you are having with the receiver. Your tone while communicating with superiors, peers and subordinates should be different.
4. Omit expressions that irritate, hurt, or belittle.
5. Grant and apologize good-naturedly
6. Courtesy stems from sincere you-attitude.

3.1.7 Correctness

Correctness is understood in terms of the appropriate choice of words and tone for communicating the message as well as the correctness of the information.

The correctness principle comprises more than proper grammar, punctuation, and spelling. One should use right level of language and accuracy of facts, figures and words.

Transmission of incorrect information to outsiders will spoil the public image of the firm. If the information is not correctly conveyed, the sender will lose credibility. So any message should not be transmitted unless one is absolutely sure of its correctness.

The term correctness, as applied to a business message, means the writer should:

- i. Use correct grammar and appropriate language
- ii. Include only accurate facts, and figures
- iii. Maintain acceptable writing mechanics
- iv. Choose nondiscriminatory expressions
- v. Apply all other pertinent C qualities

Examples:

i. A truck hit him hardly, leading to a fractured hand.

‘Hardly’ refers to something scarcely done. A truck hardly hitting someone should not be cause for worry!

When force is implied, the correct sentence will be –

A truck hit him hard, leading to a fractured hand.



Check for accuracy: The last step in the seven golden principles of communication is a check and recheck for accuracy. The message must not be erroneous. Before the written message is sent it should be checked for logic, structure, content and grammar for errors. In an oral message also, one must do a thorough check on the logic and structure of the content to be delivered. Instead of apologizing at a later date for mistakes in the message it is better to check and ensure that the facts, figures and tone are accurate and appropriate.

Example:

Sneha, the team leader, wanted to thank Garima, her team member, for helping her in preparation of annual report. As a gesture of thanks, she sent Garima a note: “I would be happy to have you for dinner on Friday night”

Missing out on one word, Viz., ‘over’, in the message, “I would be happy to have you for dinner on Friday night” made the message of Sneha cannibalistic in nature.

3.2 The Four Ss of Business Communication:

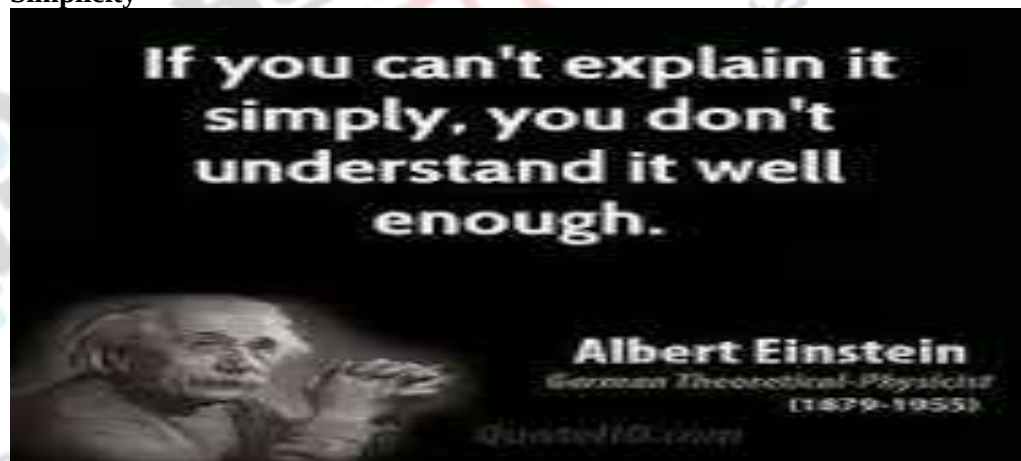
An understanding of the 4 S’s is equally important:



3.2.1 Shortness

Sender should avoid very long sentences which can make listening a very painful and boring exercise resulting in distributed attention of receiver. Sender should try to make each paragraph of just one or two ideas. Transmission and comprehension of brief message is going to be faster and more effective. Flooding messages with high sounding words does not create an impact.

3.2.2 Simplicity



Simpler the message, easier for the receiver to understand it. Confusing and difficult words should be avoided to get an effective message from the audience. The most important skill of a communicator is to communicate the most complex things in the most simple words. But this is possible only when the communicator has clarity in thinking.

3.2.3 Strength

The message is strengthened if the receivers have full faith in the credibility of the sender. Also if the sender himself is sure and convinced about his/her own message then the message will have more impact on the receiver.

3.2.4 Sincerity

Sender should be sincere while communicating the message. If sender wants to have a genuine and long lasting impact of message on the audience he should be serious and sincere while

sending the message. And if the sender is genuine it will be reflected in the manner in which he communicates.

4. Relevance of Principles of Business Communication:

4.1 Relevance of C's of business communication:

C's	Relevance
Completeness	Increased Effectiveness
Conciseness	Saves Time
Consideration	Builds Trust
Concreteness	Reinforces Confidence
Clarity	Makes Comprehension Easier
Courtesy	Improves Relationships
Correctness	Builds Confidence

4.2 Relevance of four S's of Communication:

S's	Relevance
Shortness	Economizes
Simplicity	Impresses
Strength	Convinces
Sincerity	Appeals

(Source: <http://icmabstudycircle.blogspot.in>)

5. Summary:

Communication is the soul of any relationship or business. Communication is effective when it produces the desired action in the audience. Effective communication means message is understood and acted upon, and not merely sent to the recipient. But for the effective message, communication needs to adhere to some basic principles like Completeness, Conciseness, Consideration, Concreteness, Clarity, Courtesy, Correctness, Shortness, Simplicity, Strength and Sincerity. And all these principles help the sender to make message more effective. Thus sender can have a positive impact on all the stakeholders of the organization, including employees, customers, suppliers and other associates.

